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front, the first flashpoint came when George Russell (**above**) went wide at the Turn 10 hairpin, a mistake he would repeat throughout the weekend. The error allowed Kimi Antonelli a stab at the lead, only to be pushed off the track on the outside at the final corner and then again into Turn 1 on the following lap.

Antonelli's second ill-fated attempt at the final turn resulted in a lock-up that cost him second place to Lando Norris. The Italian was quick to complain on the radio about what he felt was a dangerous shut-the-door move, only to cop some flak from team principal Toto Wolff. "Concentrate on the driving please and not the radio moaning," came the instruction.

The battle only intensified on race day. McLaren's decision to start on intermediate tyres based on the weather radar proved disastrous and, despite taking the lead into Turn 1, Norris had to pit for a tyre change just two laps in. That set the stage for round two of the Russell-Antonelli tussle.

After losing out at the start, Russell took the lead thanks to superior straight-line speed on the final straight. Antonelli almost rear-ended the Briton due to a lock-up in the dirty air, only just managing to steer the car away at the last second.

Despite repeated mistakes into the hairpin, Russell managed to maintain the lead with extra battery

power, placing his car perfectly ahead of the corners.

The tantalising battle, which saw the lead change hands multiple times, was eventually settled by rotten luck as Russell's engine gave up at the final turn, forcing him to pull over. His misery, coupled with McLaren's costly gamble at the start, allowed former world champions Lewis Hamilton and Max Verstappen to finish on the podium behind Antonelli.

"Not really the way I wanted to win the race. It was a tough fight with George. It was intense but fun. Would have been nice to see how it ended up," Antonelli said afterwards. The 19-year-old now leads the drivers' championship by 43 points ahead of his teammate. The Ferrari duo of Charles Leclerc and Hamilton are now within touching distance of the second Mercedes as well.

Antonelli leads the head-to-head battle 4-1 against his senior teammate this year. Russell will need to cut into the points gap before conceding too much momentum. And that means there will likely be more such battles at the front between the two Silver Arrows.

Will the title fight descend into the infamous Hamilton-Nico Rosberg territory? And will that force Mercedes to curtail the wheel-to-wheel racing that was on display at the Circuit Gilles Villeneuve? A box-office battle between teammates is upon us.



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MotoGP



Marco Bezzecchi extended his lead atop the MotoGP rider's championship with victory at the Italian Grand Prix at Mugello.

The 27-year-old won his fourth race of the season, his first since the United States Grand Prix in March, to extend Aprilia's blazing start to the season. Jorge Martin completed a 1-2 for the side ahead of the Ducati's Francesco Bagnaia who achieved his joint best result this season in third.

Bezzecchi made amends for his poor start during the Sprint Race where he dropped down places after starting on pole. The Italian rider eventually managed to recover and finish fourth. It was still a positive result for Aprilia as Trackhouse Racing's Raul Fernandez ran away with the race win ahead of Martin. Fabio di Giannantonio, the lead Ducati rider in the standings, rounded out the Sprint podium. Ahead of the Hungarian Grand Prix, Bezzecchi leads teammate Martin by 17 points.